Building a Home Lab Using the Free Citrix XenServer 6

Citrix recently released XenServer 6, codenamed Boston, based on the open source Xen hypervisor 4.1. As the version number 6.0 implies, this is a major new release of the product, and features new optimisations and scalability additions. Let's use it to set up a virtualised home lab.

IT enthusiasts always keep experimenting with operating systems and various configuration scenarios, and do require some kind of home lab. Citrix XenServer 6.0 is best suited for building virtualised home labs for free. It is a complete bare-metal, managed, server virtualisation platform based on powerful open source Xen technology. Citrix XenServer's free licence offering makes it feasible for a home virtualisation lab.

You will get the hypervisor for free, but you still require decent hardware to run your home lab on. Citrix XenServer can be installed on any server hardware that has a CD/DVD drive manufactured in the last three years. But in our case, we are going to install it on a system with a processor made for the desktop. To successfully virtualise your home lab, you require a 64-bit CPU with VT-x or AMD-V features. To identify a processor's virtualisation extension, you can run the following command:

```
grep –E  --color 'vmx|svm' /proc/cpuinfo
```

…or you can use a free Windows-based tool called CPU-Z if you are on a Microsoft system. Intel and AMD both have a huge line of VT-x and AMD-V processors ranging from the

XenServer Features	
Free Virtual Infrastructure	Free
XenServer Hypervisor	✔
Conversion Tools	✔
Management integration with Microsoft System Center VMM	✔
Resilient distributed management architecture	✔
VM disk snapshot and revert	✔
XenCenter Management Console	✔

Figure 1: Free licence offering

Figure 2: Text-based installation